
Autumn Nights at the Palace Starlight Tours Moonlight Tours and the Royal Culture Festival The Complete Guide to

****Subtitle****

A completely different world from daytime Gyeongbokgung (#37)
a guide to the palace night and experience programs that run only in

Why "Night" at the Palace — And Why Read This Now

Seoul's five grand palaces are open to daytime visitors any time, for just a few thousand won. But **the palace at night is a different animal** — it opens only through premium, small-group, reservation-only programs that come with expert guides and royal court refreshments, and the autumn sessions are competitive enough that even Koreans have to win a **lottery draw** (추첨) to get in. There's no walking up on the day as a foreign traveler — **applying and buying tickets weeks before your trip is the only way in.**

Category	Daytime Palace Visit	Autumn Night Program
Entry	Walk-up ticket (around ₩3,000)	Application, lottery, and advance purchase only
Group size	Unlimited (crowds)	Small, capped per session
Experience	Free self-guided visit	Guided tour + night-only hall access + refreshments/performance
Cost	A few thousand won	₩30,000–60,000

① Confirmed 2026 Autumn Schedule (Web-Verified)

1. Gyeongbokgung Starlight Night Tour (Byeolbit-yahaeng, 경복궁 별빛야행) — Sep 2 – Oct 24 (Confirmed)

- The flagship night program: a guided walk through Gyeongbokgung (경복궁) after dark that includes a **Suragan** (수라간, **the palace's royal kitchen**) **experience and royal court refreshments** (궁중 다과). ₩60,000 per person.
- Ticketing flow (based on the actual 2026 autumn session): **application window (8/14–20) → lottery results (8/24) → winners' advance purchase window (8/25–27, 2 tickets per person)**. If the application window has already closed by the time you're reading this, the realistic play is to watch for a **returned-ticket release** (취소표) **or the next session announcement**.

2. Autumn Royal Palace Culture Festival (Gungjung Munhwa Chukjeon, 궁중문화축전) — Oct 7 – Oct 11 (Confirmed)

- The biggest palace event of the year, held simultaneously across **five palaces and a royal shrine** — Gyeongbokgung, Changdeokgung, Deoksugung, Changgyeonggung, and Jongmyo. It mixes free programs with reservation-based ones, making it the **lowest-barrier way** to catch a palace's autumn night atmosphere without any advance booking at all.

3. Changdeokgung Moonlight Tour (Dalbit-gihaeng, 창덕궁 달빛기행) — Autumn Session Sep 4 – Oct 26 (Per the Palace's Official IG Repost)

- A night tour that goes as far as the Huwon (후원, Changdeokgung's Secret Garden) under moonlight, ₩30,000 per person, lottery-based. The autumn session schedule was announced via the palace's official channel — this is the most competitive program on the list, so **move the moment the application announcement goes up**.

4. Other Autumn Palace Experiences (Announced Per Session)

- **Gyeongbokgung Saeng-gwabang** (생과방, Sep 3 – Nov 3, ₩15,000) — a tasting experience for royal court sweets and tea in the Sojubang hall. The lowest price point among the autumn programs.
- **Gyeongbokgung Suragan Tasting Experience** (수라간 시식공감, Sep 17 – Sep 26, ₩25,000) — a royal-cuisine tasting program, a short ten-day window.
- **Changgyeonggung Yayeon** (창경궁 야연, an evening performance program), and more — quick to sell out once a session opens.

The exact dates and prices for the item-4 programs and the Moonlight Tour's autumn session are **subject to change until officially announced** — treat the ticketing platforms and the official channels of the Royal Palaces and Tombs Center (궁능유적본부) and the Royal Palace Culture Festival as the source of truth.

② How Korea's Ticketing System Works — Application → Lottery → Purchase

This is the part that trips up foreign visitors the most. It isn't first-come, first-served:

1. **Application** (응모): Apply through the application page during a set window — this step doesn't involve any payment. 2. **Lottery** (추첨): Winners are drawn at random from applicants — check the results on the announcement date. 3. **Advance purchase window** (선예매): Only winners can pay, within a set window (miss it, and your slot is automatically forfeited and released as a returned ticket). 4. **Returned tickets** (취소표): Leftover slots after the payment deadline sometimes go on general sale — a second chance for anyone who didn't win the lottery.

- Since purchases run through domestic Korean ticket platforms, **foreign cards and overseas sign-ups sometimes get blocked** — some sessions set aside a **separate quota for foreign visitors**, so check the announcement for a "Foreigner" line first. If you're locked out, having a Korean friend or your hotel concierge book on your behalf is the realistic workaround.

③ Which Program Should You Pick — By Traveler Type

Type	Top Pick	Why
Wants the best odds of getting a booking	Royal Palace Culture Festival (10/7–11)	Mostly free, walk-up programs — some need no lottery at all

Type	Top Pick	Why
Wants the richest experience	Gyeongbokgung Starlight Night Tour	Refreshments + Suragan + night hall access — the most complete package
Wants romance and the Secret Garden	Changdeokgung Moonlight Tour	A night in the normally-closed Secret Garden — the hardest ticket to get
Needs schedule flexibility	Smaller experiences like Saeng-gwabang and Yayeon	Frequent sessions mean better odds of catching a returned ticket

Prep Checklist (Starting 4–6 Weeks Before Your Trip)

- [] **Follow the announcement channels** — check the Royal Palace Culture Festival and Royal Palaces and Tombs Center (궁능유적본부) official pages regularly starting 6 weeks out (application windows are usually open for under a week)
- [] **Calendar all three ticketing dates** — application, results, and advance purchase (miss even one, and your shot is gone)
- [] **Check for a foreign-visitor quota** — look for a "Foreigner" line in the announcement first; if there isn't one, have a backup plan for booking through someone local
- [] **Have a lottery-loss Plan B** — set an alert for returned-ticket releases, and line up a free Royal Palace Culture Festival program as a backup
- [] **On the day:** night palaces keep lighting minimal — flash photography is customarily off-limits, wear comfortable walking shoes, and bring a layer for the cool autumn night air
- [] Pair it with a daytime palace visit — an early morning at Gyeongbokgung (경복궁, see the early-morning strategy in #37) and Bukchon (북촌, #38) in the morning, then the night program in the evening, makes for a complete day

Keep Reading

- **#37 Gyeongbokgung Guide** — the daytime version and the early-morning strategy · **#38 Bukchon Hanok Village**
- **#1310 Overrated vs. Underrated** — the evidence behind the "Gyeongbokgung is best early morning" call
- **#1314 Yellow Seoul Ginkgo Guide** — the natural next step after late-October palace stone walls
- **#224 Full Night View Guide** — night view alternatives outside the palace walls

Verification Notes (Pre-Publish Check)

- **Fact anchor** (web-verified 2026-08-20): Starlight Night Tour Sep 2–Oct 24, ₩60,000, application 8/14–20, results 8/24, advance purchase 8/25–27 (2 tickets/person) / Autumn Royal Palace Culture Festival Oct 7–11, 5 palaces + Jongmyo Shrine. (Updated 2026-08-20) Moonlight Tour autumn session Sep 4–Oct 26, ₩30,000 / Saeng-gwabang Sep 3–Nov 3, ₩15,000 / Suragan Tasting Experience Sep 17–Sep 26, ₩25,000 — per the palace's official channel IG repost (bukchon_masil DNWz-iwJFt5, seed report §2-C) — keep the "per the official IG repost" caveat in the body text.
 - **Foreign-visitor booking constraint:** the domestic-platform/overseas-card issue is based on general precedent, framed carefully as "some sessions set aside a separate foreign-visitor quota" rather than asserted as universal.
 - **Creative boundary:** ticketing-platform company names kept to a minimum (referred to as "official channels"), prices stated only for officially confirmed items.
 - **Coverage check:** zero prior pieces on the palace-night-program axis — #37 and #38 cover daytime visits, #1310 only mentions time-of-day in passing (checked 2026-08-20). Based on the seed report §3, Category C, material #8.
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Tags

#GyeongbokgungNight #MoonlightTour #RoyalCultureFestival #PalaceNight #AutumnSeoul
#ReservationRequired #KeyChinGu